

# NEW DECADE GREAT EXPECTATIONS

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*"It was the best of times, it was the worst of times;  
It was the age of wisdom, it was the age of foolishness;  
It was the epoch of belief, it was the epoch of incredulity;  
It was the season of Light, it was the season of Darkness;  
It was the spring of hope, it was the winter of despair;  
We had everything before us, we had nothing before us;  
We were all going directly to Heaven, we were all going the  
other way."*

**T**his is the opening paragraph of *A Tale of Two Cities* by Charles Dickens. It describes to me so well the last decade that we have all lived through. Now, we assemble here as survivors, scarred and battered but, nevertheless, survivors of a roller-coaster decade. A decade that began with the horrible sight of the burning towers and ended with the fall of the highest temples of capitalism. But it was also a decade which saw the world economy grow by 3.5 per cent in spite of the meltdown in 2008 and saw over 250 million people lifted from the bonds of poverty worldwide.

Still, we are here at the dawn of the new decade, refusing to wallow in the nastiness of the past or rest on its laurels but to look into the possibilities of the future. India Today Conclaves have always been about mapping the future, about learning from the ruins and triumphs of yesterday and making sense of tomorrow. Every year, the best and the brightest from all realms of human endeavour—politics or economy, culture or science—come together in what has become the most anticipated event in ideas. Ideas that question the certainties of the moment, that provoke, challenge, and entertain. Ideas that take us to the wonderment of inventive minds. Ideas that herald change. The promise of change is the oldest cliché in politics but has been the most effective weapon of mass seduction in the last decade.

So shall I say, welcome to another round of crystal-ball gazing? This time too, our fortune-tellers are a formidable lot. Leaders in politics, business, science, technology, fiction and cinema. All pioneers and innovators who continue to defy the frontiers of knowledge and are the first citizens in the republic of imagination. When I look back, I realise it has been a passage through the waystations of history. And history has been an uninvited delegate at all our Conclaves, giv-

ing them a rare immediacy and intimacy. If we were to read the deliberations of the last eight conclaves, they form a loose narrative of the ideas that have shaped the last decade, of what went wrong and what should have been done. The theme of this year only marks the new chapter in a story that is still evolving—New Decade: Great Expectations.

Certainly, our expectations are exaggerated by our memories of an eventful decade. On that September morning nine years ago, the first decade of the 21st century was introduced to a new enemy of civilisation whose shadow still looms large—global terrorism which is both faceless and borderless. It also brought to us a new global leadership of moral activism. America's war on terror was more than a military rejoinder to the authors of 9/11. It was a moral war. And Afghanistan was its first battlefield. Followed by another in Iraq, on somewhat flimsy grounds. The war is still on with a new commander-in-chief who has a new moral vision and lots of good intentions. However that may be, I believe, it will end badly. The Americans will eventually pull out because of domestic compulsions and these countries will probably descend into chaos and civil war. This will mean trouble for everyone, particularly for India.

The Bush administration may have disintegrated the central base of Al Qaeda and the chief jihadist taken to the cave, but the spirit of hate has not died down. Datelines of terror continue to multiply: Bali, Madrid, London, Mumbai and more. With paradise in their eyes and hate in their hearts, the jihadis continue to slaughter and get slaughtered. When we talk about terror, we cannot escape our own neighbourhood. Pakistan was the recurring connection in every terror attack. All the roads, inevitably, led to the industrial base of jihad that was next door. Its victims included not only the innocents in far flung countries but its own daughter who dared to promise. The vivacious Benazir Bhutto was our gala dinner speaker two years ago. She told me that she wanted to return next year. She couldn't. Her homecoming a few months later came to a tragic end when bombs silenced her arguments for change. From the ashes of her death rose Pakistan's yet another tenuous tryst with democracy which ended General Musharraf's military dictatorship. He was our gala dinner speaker last year where, in a somewhat hostile environment, he gave as good as he got.